

In the image with the food in it, when the text overlaps the food, it's still hard to read. What are some solutions to this where we still keep the food in the background behind the text? Would inverting the color of the text when it overlaps the image of the food work? Or what would work?

Thought for ... >

Yeah, your eyes are not lying to you – once text actually overlaps real food photos, it gets dicey **fast**. Simply inverting the text color where it crosses the image *sounds* clever, but in practice it's:

- Hard to implement cleanly (especially for print)
- Visually noisy (text flickers between dark/light as it crosses colors)
- Still not guaranteed to meet contrast / readability

Much better is to **keep the images as “suggestion only” and make the text live on its own clear layer**.

Here are practical options that *do* work while keeping food in the background:

1. Watermark the food harder (fade + desaturate + blur)

Keep what you already like but push it further:

- Opacity: **5–8%** (not 15–20%)
- Desaturate: `filter: grayscale(70–100%)`
- Slight blur: `filter: blur(1–2px)`

Result: your eye still sees “plate of pasta” but it’s more like a pattern than a picture, so the black text reads fine.

```
.day-hero { position: absolute; inset: 0; width: 100%; height: 100%; object-fit: cover;
opacity: 0.06; /* super faint */ filter: grayscale(80%) blur(1px); z-index: 0; }
```

If you do only one thing, do this.

2. Put the text on a slightly opaque panel

This is the most bullet-proof pattern for both screen and print.

- Food image sits full-size under the day.
- Text sits in a box with a subtle light background, so the food “peeks out” around the edges.

```
.day-content { position: relative; z-index: 1; background: rgba(255, 255, 255, 0.88); /* or
warm beige */ padding: 4px 8px; border-radius: 4px; }
```

You still see the food around the panel and a bit through it, but the letters always sit on a light, solid-ish tone.

3. Use a gradient overlay instead of raw image

If the problem is mostly where the image is bright behind text (white pasta, bright highlights), add a gradient overlay on top of the photo:

```
.day::before { content: ""; position: absolute; inset: 0; background: linear-gradient(to
bottom, rgba(253,247,240,0.95) 0%, rgba(253,247,240,0.85) 40%, rgba(253,247,240,0.75)
100%); z-index: 0; }
```

- The food still shows through faintly.
- The gradient ensures the text area is always over the lightest part.

4. Text treatments (use sparingly)

These can *help*, but shouldn’t be your only solution:

- **Slight dark text + subtle shadow:**

```
body { color: #2b251f; } .day-content { text-shadow: 0 0 1px rgba(255,255,255,0.7); }
```

- **Stroke/outline text** (looks okay for big headings, too busy for ingredients).

For accessibility and printing, try to keep text **one color** (dark) on basically light backgrounds; avoid per-pixel color inversion.

Why *not* invert text color over the picture?

- On something like a salad (green, red, yellow), the algorithm will constantly flip individual letters between light/dark.
- That creates visual noise, especially for long ingredient lists.

- Printers may dither or slightly mis-register the “inversion”, making it even harder to read.
- It breaks your ability to guarantee contrast for users with low vision.

So: **keep text color constant; make the background behave.**

Recommended combo for your cookbook pages

For your weekly plan specifically, I'd do:

1. Hero food image as an **absolute-positioned, grayscale, 5–8% opacity layer**.
2. Each day's text inside a **rounded, semi-opaque light panel** (`rgba(255, 252, 246, 0.9)`).
3. Maybe a tiny text shadow or 1px darker outline on headings only.

You'll still get the cozy “food behind the plan” vibe, but everything will read clearly and still fit in 1–2 pages.